

[Introduce Self]

Today I'd like to tell you about a paper I've been working on that asks the following interpretative question "Does 'Ought' Imply 'Can' in the Nicomachean Ethics?"

The recommendation of the paper is: yes. 'Ought' implies 'Can', provided we take the nuances and qualifications I'm going to mention seriously.

The nuance will fall out of how we choose to understand the sense of 'ought', the scope of 'can', and the force of 'imply' in different contexts. There are six considerations to my argument which correspond to the six conclusions you see at the top of the handout. They are each laid out in more depth with textual excerpts from the Reeve translation below.

As you can see, I'm going to begin by arguing that ought implies can in the scope of deliberation. From there I'll suggest there's good reason to extend this reading outside the scope of deliberation. We can also weaken the reading from an argument about a conceptual entailment between 'ought' and 'can' to a broader sensitivity to the demandingness of what we ought to do.

And when we start looking at particular cases, it might not be merited to use the conceptual reading anyway. I'll discuss the case of the incurably vicious person which has a lot of moving parts that are in a position to throw a wrench in my interpretation. And at the end I'll complete the account by touching on Aristotle's concept of 'wish'.

[Pause]

By way of introduction and to motivate the paper I should say that philosophers today are mostly interested in what is technically the contrapositive formulation of the principle. When I am unable to do something, it follows either that it's not the case that I ought to do it, or that it's not appropriate for me to be asked to do it.

Sometimes we get interested in a weakened conception of the principle that's something more like a demandingness constraint. When it's physically and psychologically possible for me to do something, but it's too demanding that I be asked to really do it, then it's not the case that I ought to do it.

Both of these formulations give us what we may call a conceptual entailment or an inference rule between ‘ought’ and ‘can’. I’m distinguishing the contrapositive formulation of the principle from the standard formulation because the standard formulation is a great deal more arcane.

We find it most influentially in Kant, for whom the concept ‘morally ought’ conceptually entails ‘can’. Since there’s an inference rule from ‘morally ought’ to ‘can’, when I know I ‘morally ought’ to do something I am actually in a position to learn that I am able to do it. Importantly the concept ‘morally ought’ also has inference rules to and from related concepts like ‘morally blameworthy’.

[Pause]

With that background on the table, I’m now going to go through the six considerations more explicitly. The first is what I’ll call the doability constraint. This will be by far the strongest consideration since it’s not really an interpretative move, so I’ll take it as the baseline. Aristotle says directly in several places and in a few different ways that the proper objects of deliberation are only those things doable in action. This is [T1] on your handout.

Let me flag that I am going to use the term ‘deliberatively ought’ to pick out the prescriptions of deliberation, which more technically are just the prescriptions of correct reason in accord with correct desire. On another gloss, what I deliberatively ought to do is what a person of practical wisdom would do.

Necessarily, whatever I deliberatively ought to do is something I am able to do. ‘Deliberatively ought’ conceptually implies ‘can’.

I’ll say in passing here that although the entailment goes in both directions, the standard formulation isn’t terribly interesting in the NE. Between what I can do and what I ought to do, the order of discovery always starts with what I can do. I’ll never learn what I can do by thinking about what I ought to do.

[Pause]

Book Ten poses some problems if we want to extend the doability constraint outside the scope of deliberation. The constraint was, after all, about the things doable in action. Contemplation on the other hand—which is, if anything, what we ought to be in the business of doing according to Aristotle—is not primarily to be

construed as an action. Voluntary actions for Aristotle are external movements of the body brought about by an internal cause.

So in the case of activities that don't count as actions, I'd like to give you the following recommendation. Take a look at [T2]. It's written that one must *as far as possible* immortalize.

Contemplation is the capacity which is most excellent since it is most like the gods. But I am not a god, so I shouldn't be silly: of course I only ought to contemplate in the manner and to the extent which is possible for me as a human.

I'll return to this with the sixth point with the discussion of 'wish', but I think we have good reason to extend the doability constraint beyond the scope of action to include all possible activities. Prescriptions across the board exclude what's impossible.

[Pause]

So I've just given you two reasons to think that, if I learn, in the most expansive sense, that I am unable to do something, then I am in a position to infer, and in fact I'm required to infer, that it's not a proper object of deliberation and that it's not a contemplative activity I ought to engage in.

The next two considerations are targeted at weaker readings of the principle. The first has to do with the demandingness constraint I mentioned earlier.

It's a familiar idea to readers of Aristotle that his accounts of virtue and blameworthiness are sensitive to what is and what is not up to us. The less wealthy can be just as generous as the wealthy even if they would lose out going, as it were, drachma for drachma. That's [T3].

And it's similar for people who fail to choose what's choiceworthy because they lack scientific knowledge. If I desire correctly but, by chance, I lack teachers of particular scientific matters, I'm not blameworthy when I make a mistake due to that ignorance. That's [T4].

So it looks like Aristotle is sensitive to demandingness considerations like the ones we take to be valuable components of our ethical and moral theorizing today.

[Pause]

So, again, the aim of the paper is to see whether a reading of conceptual entailment or of an inference rule between what I ought to do and what I am able to do is merited. But when we start looking at particular cases, we might need to hold a slightly weaker reading.

Consider [T5]. A debtor ought to repay their creditor if possible. But if the debtor is unable to repay, it's not the case that the creditor ought to make a claim of the debtor. When can read this in at least three ways.

If Aristotle is saying something about the *inference* both parties ought to make, then the correct reading of 'imply' in this case is conceptual entailment.

If Aristotle is saying that there's no *point* in asking for repayment since of course the debtor is unable to repay, then the correct reading of 'imply' in this case is presupposition. Utterances with prescriptive content presuppose that the subject of the prescription is able to do what is prescribed.

If Aristotle *is* saying that there is a point in asking for repayment, but that the point is to do something vicious with the utterance like being belligerent or harassing the hearer, then the correct reading of 'imply' is something more like pragmatic implication. Of course I would be vicious for demanding you to repay a debt when you are unable to do so. Then I ought not make the demand because doing so is vicious, not simply because you're unable.

To be transparent, this is the case that I found when writing the paper but it has the confounding feature that it comes up in the discussion of friendship. It could be that, say, the right reading is pragmatic implication but only when it comes up between friend debtors and friend creditors.

[Pause]

I have two final points. The first is this terribly interesting passage that I hope you are already familiar with on the topic of the incurably vicious person. This is [T6] on your handout.

A possible argument to the effect that my thesis is inconsistent goes something like this. The incurably vicious person is clearly blameworthy for her actions, since they issue from an internal cause led by her incorrect, depraved desires.

Recall that you ought to be virtuous because you desire to have eudaimonia over a complete life and being virtuous is what gets you there and keeps you there. So you ought to be virtuous and you fail to do so if you're vicious. So the incurably vicious person ought not be vicious. But she is incurable. So she ought to do otherwise but is unable to do so. Ought doesn't imply can.

This argument is pretty troubling for my interpretation if it's right. What I would like to say to this objection is the following. I hope you'll help during the Q&A if I've misunderstood Aristotelian causation in a major way, since it's not something I've spent a lot of time with outside this project.

For Aristotle, actions are blameworthy or worthy of reproach in virtue of the starting point internal to the doer that makes them voluntary. More broadly, agents are blameworthy for their vicious character. An agent's character is made vicious by taking blameworthy actions repeatedly and by habituating the wrong attitudes towards what they are doing and what occurs.

I think that in the case of the incurably vicious person, the nearest internal cause is not the relevant one. Instead, it's the internal cause at the point where she, so to speak, 'let the stone go'. At that point, her character was still open. At that point, it was possible for her to do otherwise. It's at this point when her character is open that she ought to have done otherwise and once she has let the stone go, this is no longer the case.

To clarify this a bit further, it is useful to remember that our intuitions about moral blameworthiness may be confounding when trying to make sense of the tie between reproach and action in Aristotle. As Anscombe says of Aristotle in her 1958 article "Modern Moral Philosophy", "any derogatory criticism, say of workmanship of a product or the design of a machine, can be called blame or reproach."

The intuition that necessarily one can infer from blameworthiness of an action to the conclusion that the action ought not have been taken does not apply so readily in Aristotle. The inference, I am claiming, is defeasible. It is defeasible especially by the doability constraint. Once the incurably vicious person's character has become closed off and she can no longer become a virtuous person, it really is not the case that she ought to do otherwise. Ought does imply can.

[Pause]

A final note to complete the account. Earlier when I said that there's good reason to extend the scope of ought implies can from what's doable in action to all possible activities, I alluded to Aristotle's concept wish. If you look at [T7], you'll see that activities and things which are impossible for us to do are the proper objects of 'wish'. We often feel the normative grip of things we are unable to do and a proper argument for ought implies can needs to deal with this datum. I take it that 'wish' plays this role.

To summarize.

When I learn I cannot take an action, I am in a position to infer that it's not the case that correct reason and correct understanding would come to accord in prescribing it. It's not the case that I deliberately ought to do something I cannot. There's good reason to think this extends to activities: when I learn that an activity is impossible, it's not the case that I ought to engage in it. And when we appeal to Aristotle's concept 'wish', this interpretation looks pretty strong.

Though, when we look at particular cases, textual evidence might not be sufficient to establish that conceptual entailment is what's going on underneath the hood. It might be an appeal to presupposition or pragmatic implication.

It also looks like Aristotle is sensitive to the demandingness considerations that underwrite the principle, whatever reading of 'imply' we take.

If you buy my story about the incurably vicious person, then I think the argument is in a pretty good place. But there are a lot of moving parts to that story. So I'd be very glad to hear any and all comments or to talk more after the session.